The function returns an integer value of the number of matching bytes between the strings (not characters; like `levenstein()`, this function is binary safe but not multi-byte safe). `similar_text()` also accepts an optional third argument, which is passed by reference and will have the percentage similarity assigned if it is present (which saves you the bother of calculating it yourself).

Testing for Sub-strings

Perhaps the most common use case, after testing or comparing entire string values, is to do the same for just a portion (or sub-string) of a string. PHP offers several functions for searching for a particular sequence of bytes (or characters, for the `mb_*` functions) or comparing a subset of bytes:

Table 8-10. *Sub-string test functions*

`str_contains()`
`str_starts_with()`
`str_ends_with()`
	Test for sub-string at start, end, or anywhere in a string

`strncmp()`	Binary-safe comparison of first N bytes

`strpos()`, `mb_strpos()`
`stripos()`, `mb_stripos()`
`strrpos()`, `mb_strrpos()`
`strripos()`, `mb_strripos()`
	Return position of first occurrence of sub-string

`strspn()`, `strcspn()`	Length of string consisting of chars in (or not in) a set

All of the functions above are concerned with searching a buffer of bytes to see if there is a subset of them that matches a given sequence. The `mb_*` functions will do this on a character basis.

`str_contains()`, `str_starts_with()`, `str_ends_with()`

The functions `str_contains()`, `str_starts_with()`, and `str_ends_with()` are all related: they accept the full string to be searched (the "haystack") as the first argument and a sub-string (the "needle") as the second. All return a boolean value.